

das briefing

08/04/2026

Three of today's stories are about walling off: the US regulator FCC bars Chinese robots from the American market, the think tank RAND designs sealed data centres against the theft of AI model weights, and the European Council on Foreign Relations prepares the EU for a confrontational France under Marine Le Pen. Against them stands a study from the University of Pennsylvania: a bean protein that binds HPV in saliva.

N° 01

US bars imports of foreign robots

The US Federal Communications Commission has since last week banned imports of new foreign robots, among them humanoid, four-legged and wheeled models. A task force convened by the White House justifies the ban with cyber risks to critical infrastructure; it hits China above all, which holds around 85 percent of the world market for humanoid robots. Of some 15,000 humanoids delivered in 2025, more than 5,000 each came from the Chinese makers Unitree and AGIBOT, while Tesla and Figure AI shipped a few hundred or fewer each. US start-ups thereby lose access to cheap Chinese platforms before comparable Western models exist.

quelle: MIT Technology Review · 2 independent sources

N° 02

Bean chewing gum binds HPV in saliva

Researchers at the University of Pennsylvania around Henry Daniell tested the extract of a chewing gum carrying the antiviral protein FRIL from the lablab bean, which clumps virus particles together so they can no longer infect cells. In saliva samples from head and neck cancer patients the HPV load fell by up to 93 percent; adding the peptide protegrin pushed the bacteria Porphyromonas gingivalis and Fusobacterium nucleatum to near zero with a single dose, without harming useful oral bacteria. The data come from samples, not from treated patients; a clinical trial at Penn Medicine is still pending.

quelle: ScienceDaily

N° 03

RAND designs sealed AI data centres

The US think tank RAND presents in its report RR-A4827-1 a concept for so-called Secure Inference Data Centers, special facilities at the highest security level five. These data centres are meant to protect the trained weights of AI models against theft and manipulation by state attackers, using system separation, one-way data diodes and formally verified protocols. The authors around Steven Comer recommend building them for national security and pilot projects only for now, but consider it feasible with today's technology.

quelle: RAND Corporation · unconfirmed

N° 04

ECFR warns of a Le Pen France

The European Council on Foreign Relations, a foreign policy think tank, publishes today the second version of a strategy paper on a possible election victory for Marine Le Pen in 2027. The paper updates an analysis from June 9, 2026, after Le Pen confirmed her candidacy for the French presidency. That became possible because an appeals court shortened her ban from office in early July, letting the head of the Rassemblement National run despite an upheld fraud conviction. The authors expect a confrontational leadership in Paris that wants to unwind substantial parts of French EU integration, and advise EU capitals to form coalitions of the willing that bypass Paris when needed.

quelle: European Council on Foreign Relations

N° 05

Ministers demand new health financing

Nigeria's health minister Muhammad Ali Pate, Indonesia's minister Budi Gunadi Sadikin and Donald Kaberuka, former head of the African Development Bank, declare the end of the donor-driven health model in Project Syndicate. The trigger is the collapse in development aid for health, which fell around 21 percent in 2025 to about 39 billion dollars, the lowest level since 2009, driven above all by a US withdrawal of more than 9 billion dollars. The Global Fund, historically financed by the US to a third, thereby loses its largest backer.

quelle: Project Syndicate

N° 06

Vienna researchers define bio-metals

Researchers at TU Wien and the University of Vienna measured the jaws of the marine bristle worm *Perinereis cultrifera* and derived from them a new class of material, bio-metals. The jaws consist of structural proteins and ions and carry more metal ions at the tips, which makes them especially hard there. They follow the Nix-Gao effect, in which hardness rises as indentation depth falls, a hallmark of crystalline metals. Under tension, however, they behave unlike classical metals such as copper or silver.

quelle: Nautilus

On August 12, 2026 a total solar eclipse crosses Greenland, Iceland and northern Spain. For mainland Spain it is the first total eclipse since 1905 and the opening of three eclipses between 2026 and 2028. The moon's shadow cone races across the continent at several thousand kilometres per hour, totality lasts only up to a few minutes at any one place, and exactly this scarcity drives demand. Northern Spain expects millions of visitors along the narrow path, while sales of certified eclipse glasses are already climbing eight days ahead and hotels along the zone are booked out.
